www.tntextbooks.in

The K.C. was not the sort of man to notice an absorbed silence on the part of a companion. He had been silent himself for nearly an hour in the train, and his tongue was making up for lost time. Political gossip, personal anecdote, and general observation flowed from him in an uninterrupted stream as the car sped along the country roads; from the inner history of the Dublin labour troubles and the private life of the Prince Designate of Albania he progressed with an easy **volubility** to an account of an alleged happening at the ninth hole at Sandwich, and a verbatim report of a remark made by the Duchess of Pathshire at a Tango tea. Just as the car turned in at the Brill entrance gates the K.C. captured Sletherby's attention by switching his remarks to the personality of their hostess.

"Brilliant woman, level-headed, a clear thinker, knows exactly when to take up an individual or a cause, exactly when to let him or it drop. Influential woman, but spoils herself and her chances by being too restless. No repose. Good appearance, too, till she made that idiotic change."

"Change?" queried Sletherby, "what change?"

"What change? You don't mean to say– Oh, of course, you've only known her just lately. She used to have beautiful dark brown hair, which went very well with her fresh complexion; then one day, about five weeks ago, she electrified everybody by appearing as a brilliant **blonde**. Quite ruined her looks. Here we are. I say, what's the matter with you? You look rather ill."

(slightly adapted)

About the Author

Hector Hugh Munro (18 December 1870 – 14 November 1916), better known by the pen name Saki, and also frequently as H. H. Munro, was a British writer whose witty, mischievous and sometimes macabre stories satirize Edwardian society and culture. He is considered a master of the short story, and often compared to O. Henry. Besides his short stories he wrote a full-length play, *The Watched Pot*, in collaboration with Charles Maude.

Glossary

embarked – boarded

espied – caught sight of

ineffectually – in vain

ruefully – regretfully, sorrowfully

pantomime – exaggerated behaviour

quid – (British) one pound sterling

exchequer – national treasury

crest – a symbol representing a family, reproduced on writing paper

tackle – equipment required for a task or sport

discrepancy – difference

soi- distant – self styled

astuteness – cleverness

sedately – in a dignified manner

sumptuous – expensive looking